

# Florence

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Italian Renaissance architects replicated many of the stylistic elements of ancient Rome, albeit with modern (i.e. post-Gothic) engineering skills, along with a humanist influence and ordered rationality. At Florence, one of the wealthiest cities, grand stone buildings included the Pazzi chapel (1441–78); the Palazzo Pitti, commissioned in 1458 by the Florentine banker Luca Pitti (1398–1472); the Palazzo Strozzi, built from 1489 for one of the city's richest families; and the Palazzo Medici Riccardi, designed by the architect and sculptor Michelozzo di Bartolomeo (1396–1472) and built in 1444–84 for Cosimo de' Medici, head of the banking dynasty. Massive, almost cube-like, Michelozzo's imposing construction for the Medici combined classical elements – such as fine-grained sandstone, rusticated masonry, cornices and an open, central colonnaded court (opposite) – with new Renaissance concepts. Through their highly individual interpretations of traditional elements, architects acquired an elevated status and a new artistic freedom of expression, and the new architectural ideas spread to other cities.

